chieftains. The Chola emblem was tiger and they issued square copper coins with images of a tiger on the obverse, elephant and the sacred symbols on the reverse.



Chola Coins with a tiger on the obverse, elephant and the sacred symbols on the reverse

The Pandyas

The Pandyas who ruled the southern part of Tamil Nadu are referred in the Ashokan inscriptions. Madurai was the Pandya's capital. Tamil literary tradition credits Pandyan rulers with patronizing Tamil Sangams (academies) and supporting the compilations of poems. The Mangulam Tamil-Brahmi inscription mentions the king Nedunchezhiyan. Nediyon, Mudathirumaran, Palayagasalai Mudukudumipperuvazhuthi were some of the important rulers of the dynasty. The Pandyan symbol was the fish.



Sangam Age Pandya coin with fish symbol

Velirs / Chieftains

Apart from the *Vendhars*, there were *Velirs* and numerous chieftains who occupied territories on the margins of the *muvendhar*. The *velirs* were the seven chiefs Pari, Kari, Ori, Nalli, Pegan, Ai and Athiyaman. Sangam poems write extensively about the generosity of these *velirs*. These chiefs had intimate relations with the poets of their time and were known for their large-heartedness. These chieftains had alliance with one or other of the *muvendhar* and helped them in their battles against the other *Vendhars*.

3.4 Society in Sangam Age

Many of the communities of the Iron Age society were organised as tribes, and some of them were Chiefdoms. The Sangam Age society was a society in transition from a tribal community ruled by a chief to a larger kingdom ruled by a king

Composition of the Society

Social stratification had begun to take root in Tamil society by the Sangam times. There were several clan-based communities including groups such as Panar, Paratavar, Eyinar, Uzhavar, Kanavar, Vettuvar and Maravar. The *Vendhars*, chiefs, and their associates formed the higher social groups. There were priests who were known as Antanars. There were artisan groups specialising in pottery and blacksmithy. The caste system we find in northern India did not take root in Tamil country as social groups were divided into five situational types (tamil) and related occupational patterns.

The development of agriculture and pastoral ways of life might have harmed the eco-system and the naturally available forest and wild animals. It is possible that some of the hunter-gatherers might have been pushed to the forest areas and a few might have taken up the occupation of manual labourers. The development of agriculture in the wet-land region depended on the use of certain groups of people as labourers.

Women

Women are frequently referred to in Tamil texts as mothers, heroines, and foster-mothers. friendly Women from Panar families, dancers, poets, and royal women were all portrayed in Sangam literature. There are references to women from all five eco-zones. For example, Vennikkuyathiyar is identified as a poetess from the village of Venni. There a re r eferences to

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